

Colette's Christmas Decorating Guide

Un Noël à la française

A CHRISTMAS COMPANION TO
COLETTE'S HOME BIBLE

COLETTE DUBOIS



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Once a year, fifty new objects arrive in a room in a single weekend, most of them out of boxes, many of them lit. These pages apply the whole method to that weekend: the light first, then the height, then the materials and the colour, and the short list of things not worth the money.

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Where these pages say the book, they mean Colette's Home Bible, and the page number is the book's. Every other page number is a page of this one.

BEFORE YOU OPEN A SINGLE BOX

The four errors of a Christmas room

A room you have spent a year correcting can be undone in one December afternoon, and it is almost always undone in the same four ways.

Christmas is the one time of year when nearly everybody decorates, and most people do it the way they would never furnish a room: everything at once, out of boxes, in the order the boxes come down from the cupboard. Nothing in the method changes for the season. What changes is the speed, and speed is where the errors come from.

1. **Adding before clearing.** The decorations go on top of everything that was already there, so the room gains fifty objects and loses none. The tree takes the floor of a chair that is still in the room, somewhere. Page 5.
2. **Cold light.** A strand of "bright white" lights on the tree and the ceiling light on as well, so the one season built around warm light is lit like a shop. Pages 6 to 8.
3. **One height.** Everything that glows is on the tree, at the height of the tree, and the rest of the room is dark below and above it. The room looks like a display rather than a place to sit. Page 8.
4. **The box set.** Fifty baubles of one size and one finish, a garland that matches them, a wreath that matches the garland. It is the matched three-piece suite of page 114 of the book, bought new every few years. Page 15.

THE ORDER STILL HOLDS

The order of operations on page 15 of the book — clear, light, height, texture, colour — is exactly the order to decorate in. Clear the surfaces. Plan the light, including the lights on the tree. Decide the heights: the tree, the mantel, the table, the window. Then the materials. Then, last, the colour, which is the part most people start with and the part that matters least.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF DECEMBER**
>
> *Christmas is decorated in the same order as the rest of the year, only faster. Light before baubles, always.*

These pages assume a sitting room, a table and a front door. A studio has all three in one room, which makes every page here more important, not less.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY TRUE

A French Christmas, honestly

There is no single French way to decorate for Christmas, and anyone who sells you one is selling you a catalogue. There are a few habits that are real, and they are worth knowing because they are restrained.

Most French homes have a real tree, and most of those trees are a Nordmann fir, chosen because it keeps its needles. Many families in the south set out a crèche with small clay figures from Provence. The big meal is on the evening of the twenty-fourth, and the decorations tend to stay up into early January, until the galette des rois closes the season. None of that is a style. It is a calendar, and a calendar is more useful to you than a colour scheme.

THE EIGHTH OF DECEMBER, IN LYON

Every year on the evening of the eighth, Lyon puts candles in its windows: small glasses, one after another along the sills, so the whole hill glitters from the river. It began in 1852, when the city lit its windows for the new statue of the Virgin on Fourvière. In the Croix-Rousse, Mémé set ours out at dusk on the sill of the tall weavers' windows, a hand's width apart, and would not let anyone switch on the ceiling light until they had burned down. It is still the most beautiful lighting I have ever seen in a room, and it cost a few centimes.

THE WORDS YOU WILL MEET

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
le réveillon	The long dinner on Christmas Eve, and again on New Year's Eve. The table on page 17 is laid for it.
les lumignons	The little candles in glasses that Lyon sets on its window sills on the eighth of December.
la crèche, les santons	The nativity scene, and the small painted clay figures, from Provence, that fill it.
le gui	Mistletoe. In France it is kissed under at midnight on New Year's Eve, not at Christmas.
la galette des rois	The almond cake of early January, with a small figure hidden inside. Whoever finds it wears the paper crown.

STAGE ONE

Clear before you decorate

A tree is a piece of furniture two metres tall that arrives for five weeks. It has to take the place of something, and the something has to go somewhere.

The commonest Christmas room I walked into had a tree squeezed between the sofa and the window, a chair pushed against the bookcase to make space for it, and every surface carrying its usual objects plus a candle, a figure and a bowl of something. Nothing was wrong with any of the decorations. There was simply nowhere for the eye to rest, and the tree itself was lost.

THE SWAP BOX

Take one empty box down with the decorations. Every time a decoration comes out of its box, one ordinary object from the same room goes into the empty one: the bowl on the side table leaves when the candles arrive, the picture on the mantel shelf leaves when the garland goes up. The swap box goes into the cupboard the decorations came from, and in January the two swap back. The room ends December holding roughly what it held in November, which is the whole point.

WHAT TO MOVE FOR THE SEASON

- **One piece of furniture,** usually a chair or a small table, to make the tree's floor. Better out of the room for five weeks than wedged into it.
- **Half of what is on every surface.** A shelf that held seven things holds three and a candle.
- **The everyday objects in the tree's background.** A tree reads against a plain wall or a window. It disappears against a full bookcase.

THE WALKWAY

Before the tree goes in, walk the routes through the room with a full basket in your arms — door to sofa, sofa to window, door to table. A tree that you brush past every time you cross the room will be shedding needles on the floor by the twentieth and knocked over by the twenty-fifth. The clearances on page 174 of the book apply in December as they do in June.

And the empty corner of page 102 of the book? It may lend itself to the tree for five weeks. That is a loan, not a gift. It comes back on the day the tree goes out.

STAGE TWO · LIGHT

Christmas lights, and the number on the box

The kelvin number on page 34 of the book is printed on boxes of fairy lights too, and in December it matters more than at any other time of year, because for five weeks the tree is the brightest thing in the room.



FOR THE TREE AND THE WINDOW

Strands sold as **warm white** usually sit somewhere between 2700 and 3000 kelvin; strands sold as **extra warm**, **amber** or **candle** sit nearer 2200, which is the colour of a flame. Either belongs in a sitting room. **Cool white**, **bright white** and anything called daylight is the light of a shop window, and on a dark green tree it turns the needles blue-grey. If the box gives no number at all, look at the photograph on it under the shop's own cold light: if the lit bulbs look white rather than gold, they are cool.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE STRANDS**
>
> *One colour of light in a room. Every strand from the same batch, and every strand matched to the bulbs in the lamps.*

WHY THE BATCH MATTERS

"Warm white" is not a fixed colour. Two strands with the same words on the box, from different makers or different years, can differ by several hundred kelvin, and side by side on one tree the difference is obvious: one half of the tree pinkish, the other half lemon. Buy all the strands for one tree at once, from one shelf, and when one fails, replace the set rather than the strand. Test every strand in the shop if they let you, and on the floor at home before it goes anywhere near a branch.

TWO SETTINGS TO SWITCH OFF

Most strands come with eight modes, of which seven flash, fade or chase. Find the steady one and leave it there. And the colour-changing kind, which cycles through red, blue and green, does to a room what a television does: it is the only thing anybody can look at.

Lighting the tree

A tree lit from the outside looks like a cone wearing a necklace. A tree lit from the inside looks like it is glowing, and the difference is only the direction you wind the strand.

HOW MANY

A common working rule is a hundred small bulbs for every thirty centimetres, every foot, of tree height. That is generous, and it is the number for a tree that is meant to glow from across a dark room. For a softer tree, sixty or seventy a foot is plenty. Fewer than that and the strand reads as a line of dots rather than as light.

A tree of 150 cm · 5 ft	300–500 bulbs
A tree of 180 cm · 6 ft	400–600 bulbs
A tree of 210 cm · 7 ft	500–700 bulbs

HOW, IN SIX STEPS

1. **Test every strand on the floor,** plugged in, before it touches the tree. A dead strand found halfway up is an hour lost.
2. **Start at the bottom, at the trunk,** with the plug end, so the lead runs straight down to the socket and nobody sees it.
3. **Work branch by branch, not round and round.** Run the strand out along a branch to its tip and back again to the trunk, then on to the next branch. It takes three times as long as spiralling the outside and it is the whole difference.
4. **Push some bulbs deep, near the trunk.** Light from inside the tree lights the needles from behind, and that is what makes a tree glow rather than twinkle.
5. **Light it before anything else goes on.** Step back to the doorway, half close your eyes, and look for dark patches. Fix them now; you cannot once the baubles are on.
6. **Plug it into a timer.** On at dusk, off when you go to bed. It saves you the crawl behind the tree every evening and the worry every night.

READ THE SMALL PRINT ON THE PLUG

Strands can be joined end to end only up to the number the maker allows, and that number is printed on the label or the plug. Never more. And a strand made for indoors stays indoors.

THE THREE HEIGHTS, IN DECEMBER

The other lights of December

The tree is one light source at one height. The room still needs the other two, and in December it needs them more, because the tree makes everything around it look darker.

Page 28 of the book sets out the three heights every room has to be lit from: overhead, table height and floor level. At Christmas most rooms collapse to one — the tree — with the ceiling light switched on beside it when somebody needs to see. That is the worst of both: the tree loses its glow under the ceiling light, and the moment the ceiling light goes off the room is a dark box with a bright cone in one corner.

DECEMBER, HEIGHT BY HEIGHT

Overhead	off, all season
The tree, and the mantel or shelf garland	middle and high
Table lamps, as every other month	table height
Candles on the table, the low lamp in the corner	low

Light the room first and the tree second. The tree should be the brightest single thing in the room, but not the only thing; a lamp on the far side of the room from it keeps the room readable and makes the tree look brighter rather than dimmer, because the eye is no longer straining against the dark around it.

CANDLES

- **Unscented on the table,** always. A scented candle at dinner competes with the food and wins.
- **One scent per room, if any.** Three different scented candles in one room is a department store.
- **Several flames together,** at different heights, read as light. One candle alone reads as a gesture.
- **Battery candles with a timer** wherever a flame would be near greenery, curtains, a child or a cat. The good ones are hard to tell from the real thing at three metres.

NEVER

A real candle on a tree, real or artificial. Nor a flame within thirty centimetres, a foot, of anything that can burn — a garland, a ribbon, a curtain, a card on a shelf. Greenery dries out in a heated room faster than anyone expects.

Mirrors and black windows

In December there are two mirrors in every room: the one on the wall, and the window, which turns into one the moment it is dark outside and lit inside.

Page 90 of the book says that a mirror reflects whatever is in front of it, and that this is the entire mechanism. In December the useful version of that is simple. A mirror that can see candles or a lit tree doubles them for nothing. A mirror that can see the back of the tree, the tangle of leads behind it and the box the baubles came in doubles those too.

THE MIRROR ON THE WALL

- **Over a mantel,** a row of candles on the shelf below the mirror is the oldest trick in the French sitting room. The tall mirror and panel above a fireplace, the trumeau, was made for a room lit by flame, and this is what it was for.
- **From your seat,** sit where you will sit on Christmas Eve and look at the mirror. If it shows you the tree, it is working. If it shows you the ceiling or the door, move the candles rather than the mirror.
- **Behind the tree,** never. A mirror there shows the bare inner side of the tree and the trunk, and the leads running down it.

THE BLACK WINDOW

After dark, with the room lit and the street unlit, a window is a dark mirror. Stand in the doorway and look at the glass. A tree placed beside a window, a little forward of it, appears twice in the evening — once in the room and once, softer, in the glass — and it is seen from the street as well. A tree placed in front of a window, with its back to the glass, shows the street its leads and shows you its reflection from behind. Beside, not in front.

> ### COLETTE'S RULE OF THE SECOND TREE
>
> *Before you fix the tree's place, turn off the ceiling light and look for its reflection. A tree you can see twice is a tree in the right place.*

The same is true of the black window behind a dining table. Candles on a table in front of an uncurtained window at night are doubled in the glass, and many people leave the curtains open on Christmas Eve for exactly that reason. If the window looks out onto a lit neighbour or a bright street, close them; the reflection is gone and only the view remains.

STAGE THREE · HEIGHT

The right tree for the room

A tree is measured twice, once for height and once for width, and almost every tree that looks wrong in a room failed the second measurement, not the first.

HEIGHT

Measure the ceiling. Take off the stand, which lifts the tree ten to fifteen centimetres, and the topper, if there is one. What is left is the tallest tree the room can take, and the tree looks best a little short of it: a tree touching the ceiling looks wedged in, a tree with a hand of air above its top looks placed.

Ceiling 240 cm · 8 ft, with a topper	tree of about 195–210 cm
Ceiling 260 cm and more	tree of about 210–225 cm

WIDTH, WHICH IS THE ONE THAT MATTERS

A tree sold as a standard shape is usually about two thirds as wide at the base as it is tall, so a tree of two metres is about 130 cm across the bottom — well over four feet, and wider than most armchairs. In a small sitting room, that is the floor of a chair and its walkway. Ask for a slim or narrow tree, which is often closer to half its height across, or choose a shorter tree and stand it on something.

Standard tree, base width	about two thirds of its height
Slim tree, base width	about half its height
Clear floor around it, on the open sides	a walkway, 60–90 cm

WHERE IT STANDS

- **Away from heat.** At least a metre, three feet, from a radiator, a stove or a fire. A real tree beside a radiator is dry within a week.
- **Seen from the door,** so it is the first thing anybody sees coming in, and not in the walkway they use to come in.
- **Beside a window rather than in front of it,** for the reason on the previous page.
- **Near a socket,** so the lead never crosses a walkway. A lead taped across the floor is a lead somebody will trip on in the dark.

Take a tape measure to buy the tree. The ones in the yard always look smaller than they are, because the sky is a very high ceiling.

Keeping a real tree, and choosing a false one

A real tree drops its needles for one reason, and it is almost never the tree's fault. It ran out of water.

THE REAL ONE

1. **Choose by touch.** Run a branch through a closed hand. A fresh tree gives up a few needles; a tree that has been cut too long rains them. The Nordmann fir, the usual French tree, holds its needles far longer than most spruces, and that is why it is the usual French tree.
2. **Saw a fresh cut,** one or two centimetres off the base, just before it goes into water. A cut trunk seals itself with sap within hours, and a sealed trunk cannot drink.
3. **Use a stand that holds water,** plenty of it: a common rule is about a litre for every two and a half centimetres, every inch, of trunk diameter.
4. **Check the water every day,** especially in the first week, when a fresh tree can drink a surprising amount. If the level ever falls below the base of the trunk, it seals again.
5. **Keep it away from heat,** as on the previous page.

THIERRY AND THE SAW

My husband will not let a tree into the flat until he has taken his own saw to the bottom of it on the landing, with the stand already full and waiting by the window. Two minutes, he says, between the cut and the water, or you are buying a dead tree. We have never had a bare branch by New Year.

THE FALSE ONE, HONESTLY

An artificial tree is only a sound buying decision if it is kept for many years, and the studies disagree about how many. Bought, it should be judged like any piece of furniture on page 194 of the book: will it still be here, and still wanted, in ten years? That rules out the cheap, sparse, very green ones, which look artificial from the doorway and are usually replaced within three seasons. If you buy one, buy it once.

- **Look at the tips, not the photograph.** Moulded tips that imitate needles look like a tree; flat, shiny strips of plastic look like tinsel.
- **Choose a darker, slightly blue-green** over a bright lime green. Real fir is darker than people remember.
- **Unlit,** so the lights can be chosen by the rule on page 6 and replaced when they fail. A pre-lit tree with a dead strand is a tree with a dead strand for ever.

Garlands, wreaths and the mantel

Almost every garland I have seen in a client's home was too short, and almost every wreath too small. Both are measured, and neither is.

THE GARLAND

A garland laid flat along a mantel or a shelf should run the whole length and fall a little past each end, so the line continues down the sides rather than stopping at the edge. A garland hung in swags needs far more than people buy, because every dip uses length.

Laid along a shelf — length	shelf + 30–60 cm each end
Hung in swags — length	about one and a half × the width
Along a banister — length	the rail, measured, + a quarter

And thick. A thin garland on a wide mantel reads as a line, not as greenery. Two cheap thin garlands twisted together, or one bought garland filled out with real cut branches tucked into it, read as one generous one.

THE WREATH

A wreath on a front door is seen from the end of the path, and from there a small one looks like a knot. As a working guide, a wreath should be roughly half to two thirds the width of the door. A standard door of about ninety centimetres, three feet, carries a wreath of fifty to sixty centimetres.

Door 80–90 cm · 32–36 in	wreath 50–60 cm · 20–24 in
Its centre, from the floor	about eye level, 150–165 cm

THE MANTEL, IN THREE HEIGHTS

A mantel dressed with one garland and nothing else is flat. The rule on page 28 of the book applies to objects as much as to light: something low along the shelf, something at middle height, and something tall at one end — a branch in a jug, a pair of tall candles, the mirror above. Never symmetrical in every detail; a mantel with identical objects at both ends looks like a shop counter.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE GARLAND**
>
> *Measure the garland as you would a curtain. Too short and too thin is the only real mistake a garland can make.*

FOR THE RENTED FLAT, AND FOR EVERYONE IN JANUARY

Hanging it without a drill

Nothing in December needs a hole in the wall. Everything here comes down in January leaving the wall exactly as it was, which is what a deposit is for.

THE FRONT DOOR

- **An over-the-door hook,** a thin metal hanger that hooks over the top of the door. Check that the door still closes on it without forcing, and put a strip of felt where it touches the paint.
- **The ribbon instead,** which needs no hook at all: tie the wreath to a long ribbon, take the ribbon up over the top of the door and fix its end on the inside with a little tape or a drawing pin into the top edge, where nobody will ever see the mark.

WALLS, WINDOWS AND THE MANTEL

- **Adhesive hooks** follow the rules on page 133 of the book in full: half the rating, a wipe with rubbing alcohol, an hour before any weight. In winter add one more: adhesive grips badly on a cold surface, so an outside door or a window frame in a cold room needs the hook put on in the warm, and an extra day.
- **The picture rail,** if your building has one (page 91 of the book), will carry garlands and stars on cord, at any height, with no mark at all.
- **A tension rod** fitted inside the window recess carries paper stars, lights or a short garland. Nothing touches the frame but the rod's rubber ends.
- **Suction cups** belong on glass, nowhere else.
- **On a mantel,** the garland is held by weight, not glue: a heavy candle holder or a pair of books at each end, hidden under the greenery. Adhesive on a painted mantel shelf is exactly the place it takes the paint with it.

BANISTERS AND RAILS

Soft ties, ribbon or the paper-covered wire sold for gardens, wound twice around the rail and the garland together. Never adhesive on varnished wood, and never cable ties pulled tight, which mark the finish.

THE FISHING LINE

Clear fishing line disappears against a wall or a window at night, which is why it is so useful for hanging stars and baubles where you want them to float. It is also invisible to anyone walking under it. Hang it out of the way of heads, and never across a doorway.

STAGE FIVE · COLOUR, LAST

A palette for December

The tree is already green and the light is already gold. That is two of your colours chosen before you open a box, and most rooms need only one more.

A Christmas palette is usually chosen in a shop, from a display arranged under shop lighting, and then brought home to a room that has its own colours and its own light. The decorations go up, and they argue with the sofa. The cure is the one the rest of this book gives for paint: choose from the room, not for it.

CHOOSING IT, IN THREE STEPS

1. **Take the colour from the room.** Look at what already stays: the sofa, the curtains, the rug, the wood. The decoration colour should belong to one of them. A rust sofa makes copper and deep red look intended. A blue-grey room makes silver and white look intended.
2. **Add one.** Green and gold are given; add one colour, and white or cream for rest. Three colours is a palette. Five is a sale.
3. **Check it at night.** Lay the decorations on the sofa at nine in the evening, with the lamps on and the ceiling light off. That is when they will be seen, and it is when they will clash, if they are going to.

ONE METAL

Gold, brass and copper sit with warm light and look as if they are lit from inside. Silver and chrome sit with cool light, and under warm bulbs they can look grey. Choose one metal for the room's decorations and let every bauble, candlestick and bell follow it. Mixing the two is possible and is much harder than it looks, which is the definition of a thing to avoid.

THE TROUBLE WITH DEEP RED

Deep red is the colour of Christmas and the colour that disappears first in low evening light, sinking towards brown and then black long before the greens and the whites do. Give red a light of its own — a candle in front of it, a lamp beside it — or a pale neighbour, and it holds. Left in the dark corner, it is a black ribbon.

COLETTE'S RULE OF THREE COLOURS

Green, gold, and one colour that was already in the room. Everything else is white.

THE BOOK'S PAGE 114 OF THE BOOK, IN DECEMBER

Nothing that came in a box of fifty

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF THE MATCHED SET, AT CHRISTMAS**
>
> *A tree dressed from one box looks bought. A tree dressed from twenty years looks loved, and nobody can buy that.*

The box of fifty identical baubles is the three-piece suite of December. Every one of them is fine. Together they announce that the whole tree was decided in one afternoon, in one aisle.

A tree needs a great many objects, so the box is tempting, and a box of fifty is cheap. The answer is not to throw it away. It is to use it as the background and interrupt it, exactly as page 114 of the book interrupts a sofa set.

HOW TO BREAK A BOX SET YOU ALREADY OWN

- **Three sizes, not one.** Large, medium and small, in roughly one large to three medium to six small. One size on a tree flattens it into a polka dot.
- **Large inside, small outside.** Hang the big baubles deep in the tree, close to the trunk, and the small ones near the tips. It gives the tree depth, and it puts the weight on the strong part of the branch.
- **Two finishes in one colour.** Shiny and matte, or glass and painted. The same colour in two finishes looks chosen; two colours in one finish looks bought.
- **Add the things that did not come from a shop.** Dried orange slices, cinnamon sticks tied with thread, paper stars, a small wooden figure, an ornament a child made. Ten of these on a tree of fifty baubles changes the whole tree.

THE ONE-A-YEAR HABIT

Buy, or be given, or make, one ornament every December, and write the year on its string tag. In ten years the tree is a diary. It is the slowest way to decorate a tree and the only one that grows more valuable every year rather than less, which is the argument of page 120 of the book about patina, hung on a branch.

And the matched set has one honest use. A tree that must go up in an hour — in a shop, an office, a waiting room — can be dressed from one box and look perfectly correct. That is the point. It looks correct, and it looks like nobody lives there.

STAGE FOUR · TEXTURE

The four families at Christmas

Most Christmas decorations are made of one material, plastic finished to look like something else. That is why a room can be full of decorations and still look thin.

The four families on page 107 of the book — wood, textile, clay and stone, and something living — are the cure in December as in June, and December happens to be the month when the living family is easiest to bring indoors.

FAMILY	IN DECEMBER
Living	Cut branches of fir, pine or eucalyptus in a jug, tucked into a garland, laid along the table. Ivy and holly from a garden. A pot of white paperwhites or a hyacinth forced for the season.
Textile	Ribbon bought by the metre in velvet, linen or cotton rather than shiny polyester. A wool throw. A linen tablecloth, page 109 of the book.
Wood	A wooden bowl of nuts or pine cones. Wooden ornaments. The candlesticks you already own. Bare twigs from a walk, sprayed nothing at all.
Clay, glass, stone	Old glass baubles. A stoneware jug for the branches. Candles in glasses, as Lyon does on the eighth.

DRIED ORANGE SLICES, BECAUSE EVERYONE ASKS

1. Slice oranges about half a centimetre thick, and pat both sides dry with a cloth.
2. Lay them on a rack over a baking tray, in the oven at its lowest setting, around a hundred degrees Celsius, two hundred Fahrenheit, with the door just ajar.
3. Turn them every hour. They take two to four hours, and they are done when the flesh is dry and translucent and the rind no longer bends.
4. Thread them on cotton or a thin ribbon. They keep for years in a dry box.

PAPER STARS

White paper stars in a window, hung on thread from a tension rod at different heights, are the cheapest decoration in this book and one of the best. At night they glow with the room behind them; in the daytime they throw small shadows. A sheet of good paper, a pair of scissors and an evening.

GREENERY AND CHILDREN

Holly and mistletoe berries are poisonous to children and to pets. Keep both high, or choose branches without berries.

THE TWENTY-FOURTH

The réveillon table

The French have a phrase for everything that goes on a laid table, les arts de la table, and the whole of it comes down to one question: can every guest see every other guest, and their plate, by candlelight?

THE NUMBERS

Width of table per guest	60 cm · 24 in, at least
Tablecloth drop, for dinner	20–30 cm · 8–12 in
Centrepiece, low	under 30 cm · 12 in
Or tall and thin, with nothing between	above seated eye level
Candles from the nearest greenery	30 cm · 12 in, or more

THE TABLE, IN ORDER

1. **The cloth first,** white or cream, or linen in its own colour, for the reason on page 109 of the book. A cloth with a printed Christmas pattern fights the food.
2. **Light, before anything else is laid.** The ceiling light off, the pendant over the table, if you have one, at its proper low height and dimmed (page 151 of the book), and the candles placed and lit, so that you set everything else by the light it will be seen in.
3. **Greenery along the middle,** low, as a runner of cut branches straight on the cloth. It costs almost nothing, and it carries the green of the tree to the table.
4. **Plates and glasses last,** and fewer of them than the occasion seems to demand. A table so full that the candles have to be moved to serve is a table that has stopped working.

MÉMÉ'S REHEARSAL

My grandmother laid the réveillon table on the evening of the twenty-third, completely, with the candles lit, and sat in every chair in turn. She moved whatever hid a face. Then she cleared it all away, and laid it again the next evening in a quarter of the time.

The same table, with the same greenery moved to the side, serves the New Year's Eve dinner a week later. Hang the mistletoe in the doorway, not over the table.

The window from the street

In December your window is the one part of your home that strangers see, and it is seen almost only at night. Decorate it for the pavement, not for the room.

The eighth of December in Lyon is the proof that the simplest window is the most beautiful one. A row of small flames along a sill, seen from below, does more than any arrangement of lit reindeer, because it is light doing what light does best: marking the shape of the window and nothing else.

LIGHTING A WINDOW, SIMPLY

- **Along the sill,** where Lyon puts its candles: a row of small lights, or battery candles in glasses, at even spacing. A hand's width apart is enough.
- **Across the top,** a single strand along the head of the window, held by a tension rod inside the recess. Two lines of light, top and bottom, frame the glass.
- **In the middle,** one thing, or paper stars on thread at different heights. One star in a window is a sign. Twelve plastic figures is a shop.
- **The same warm light** as the tree and the lamps, for the reason on page 6. A cool-white window in a street of warm ones is the one everybody notices, for the wrong reason.

THE CURTAINS

Open, in the evening, if the window is the decoration. A lit window with the curtains drawn is a strip of light between two dark panels; with them pulled back to the edges of the frame, it is a picture. Close them at bedtime, with the timer, and the street goes dark with you.

FLAMES BEHIND GLASS

A real flame on a sill sits between the glass and a curtain. If you light real candles in a window, as Lyon does, take the curtains right back, keep the flames in glasses, and never leave the room while they burn. Otherwise, battery candles. From the street, nobody can tell the difference.

Outside the window — on a balcony, a porch, a front door — use only lights and leads made for outdoors, plugged into a socket made for outdoors. The words "indoor use only" on a box mean exactly that, and rain finds out.

THE SHORTEST LIST IN THIS BOOK, AND THE HARDEST TO KEEP

What not to buy for Christmas

The four tests on page 190 of the book apply in December like any other month. They are simply harder to hear over the music in the shop.

- **Cool-white or "bright white" lights.** They turn a tree blue-grey and a sitting room into a shop window. Page 6.
- **Strands that flash, chase or change colour,** unless they also have a steady setting you will use.
- **A pre-lit artificial tree.** When one strand dies, the tree is a dead strand for ever. Buy the tree and the lights separately. Page 11.
- **The box of fifty matching baubles,** bought new to replace last year's box of fifty. Page 15.
- **Tinsel.** Plastic film that sheds into the carpet for the rest of the winter and is rarely recyclable. Light does its job better.
- **Spray snow on the windows.** It looks like spray snow from the street, and on a bad day it looks like it until March.
- **"This year's colours".** A palette designed to be replaced next December. Page 14 has one that lasts.
- **Several scented candles for one room.** One scent per room, none on the table.
- **Shiny polyester ribbon on the roll.** Velvet, linen or cotton by the metre costs a little more, lasts for years and looks like cloth.
- **Large inflatables and plastic light-up figures** for a small flat or a balcony. They are built to be seen from a road, and a room is not a road.
- **Christmas cushion covers,** new every year. A plain cover in your one Christmas colour does the same job in December and stays out in January.
- **Anything that needs its own extension lead** across a walkway.

A FAIR WARNING, AGAIN

As with the main list, these are my opinions, formed on the job, and a family with a particular tradition — the flashing lights a grandmother loved, the box of tinsel a child insists on — should keep it. Tradition beats taste every time. These are the things to stop buying, not the things to throw away.

The ten Christmas things worth buying

Like page 196 of the book, in the order I would spend the money, and nine of the ten will still be useful in March.

1. **A timer plug,** or two. Lights on at dusk and off at bedtime, every night, without a crawl behind the tree. The cheapest thing on this page and the most used.
2. **Warm-white strands, one batch,** enough for the tree by the count on page 7. Unlit tree, separate lights, steady setting.
3. **A stand that holds water,** plenty of it, for a real tree. A tree dies in a stand that holds too little.
4. **Unscented candles,** a box of tall ones for the table and some short ones in glasses. Battery candles with a timer wherever a flame would be unsafe.
5. **Ribbon by the metre,** velvet or linen, in your one Christmas colour. It ties the wreath, the garland, the stockings and the presents, and it lasts.
6. **A garland long enough,** by the measure on page 12, or two thin ones to twist together.
7. **Cut greenery,** from a florist, a market or a garden: branches for a jug, a runner for the table, filling for the garland. It costs very little and it is the only decoration that smells right.
8. **A wreath of the right size,** and the ribbon or the over-door hook to hang it on. Page 13.
9. **One ornament,** chosen slowly, with the year written on its tag. Page 15.
10. **Boxes for putting it away,** with dividers, so that next year begins untangled. Page 23.

Most of the money goes on light and on greenery. That is not a coincidence: they are the two things a December room is actually made of.

WHAT THE WHOLE LIST COSTS

Items one to four — timers, lights, a stand, candles — are the ones that change the room, and together they cost less than a box of designer baubles. Items five to nine are the ones that make it look generous, and the greenery is the only one bought again every year. Item ten is the one that saves next December an evening.

THE QUIET PART

Who profits from a new Christmas every year

Nobody plotted it. The trade simply arranged itself around the one season in which almost everybody buys decorations, and the arrangement has a shape worth seeing.

Christmas decorations are sold in a few weeks, mostly to people in a hurry, and much of what is sold is stored in a box for eleven months and brought out again. A decoration that lasts is good for the household and bad for next year's sales. That is not anybody's fault. It is just what the season rewards, and it explains three things you will see in every shop this December.

1. **The palette changes every year.** A colour story for the season, shown on every display, so that last year's perfectly good decorations look like last year. Your tree does not know what year it is.
2. **The set is cheaper than the piece.** Fifty baubles cost little more than five good ones, so the set always looks like the sensible choice, and a tree dressed from it always looks like the shop.
3. **Everything lights up, and nothing can be repaired.** Moulded figures with the lights sealed inside, trees with the strands built in. When one part fails, the whole object is finished, and there is another on the shelf.

None of this needs a villain to work, and none of it needs you to do anything except notice. The household that buys well at Christmas is not the one that buys least. It is the one that buys things which come out of the box next year still wanted: lights that can be replaced on their own, glass that does not date, greenery that is meant to be thrown away.

THE BOX IN THE CELLAR

Our decorations live in two wine crates in the cellar, and the oldest thing in them is a glass bird with a tail of real feathers, older than my mother. It has never matched anything on any tree. It goes on first, every year, and it is the one my daughter looks for.

COLETTE'S RULE OF THE BOX

Buy for the box in the cellar, not for the photograph. A decoration is good if you are glad to unwrap it in ten years.

Safe, without spoiling it

December brings more flames, more leads and more dry wood into a home than the rest of the year together. None of the rules below costs anything, and none of them shows.

THIS IS THE ONE PAGE TO FOLLOW EXACTLY

Everything else in these pages is a matter of how a room looks. This page is a matter of whether it is still there in January. If in doubt about any appliance, any socket or any lead, ask an electrician, not a shop.

LIGHTS AND LEADS

- [ ] Every strand checked on the floor before it goes up: no cracked wire, no loose bulb, no scorch mark on the plug
- [ ] Strands joined only up to the number printed on the label
- [ ] Indoor lights indoors, outdoor lights outdoors, on an outdoor socket
- [ ] No lead under a rug, through a closed door or across a walkway
- [ ] Lights off when the house is empty and when everyone is asleep — the timer does it

FLAMES

- [ ] No candle on or near a tree, real or artificial
- [ ] Thirty centimetres, a foot, between any flame and anything that can burn
- [ ] Candles on a stable, non-flammable holder, out of reach of children and animals
- [ ] Never a candle left burning in an empty room

THE TREE

- [ ] A metre from radiators, stoves and fires
- [ ] A real tree watered every day, and taken out once it drops needles at a touch
- [ ] Stable in its stand, and tied discreetly to a hook where there are small children or a climbing cat
- [ ] Glass baubles high, where small hands and tails do not reach

THE REST

- [ ] Holly and mistletoe berries out of reach of children and pets
- [ ] Batteries for remote candles and toys stored away from small children, who can swallow button cells
- [ ] The smoke alarm tested on the day the tree goes up

EARLY JANUARY

Putting it away well

Next Christmas is decided on the day this one comes down, in about an hour, by whether the lights go into the box in a ball or on a card.

In many French homes the season ends with the galette des rois in early January, and the tree goes out soon after. Many towns collect real trees in the weeks after New Year and turn them into mulch or compost; look for the collection point your town announces, rather than leaving the tree on the pavement.

THE HOUR THAT SAVES NEXT DECEMBER AN EVENING

1. **Photograph the tree and the mantel** before anything comes down. Next year you will want to know where the bird went, and how long the garland was.
2. **Lights off the tree in reverse**, tip to trunk, and wound around a piece of stiff card, plug end first, so the plug end comes out first next year. One strand per card, and a note of its length.
3. **Batteries out** of every battery candle, every timer and every lit figure. A battery left in for eleven months can leak and ruin what it powers.
4. **Glass in egg boxes** or wrapped in tissue, never newspaper, whose ink can mark painted glass. Heaviest at the bottom of the box.
5. **Ribbon rolled, not folded**, around a cardboard tube, so it does not crease.
6. **Label the boxes by job,** not by contents: *tree, first*; *mantel*; *table*; *window*. The order you take them out next year is the order of this book.
7. **The swap box back.** The everyday objects return to their places, and the room is the room again.

WHERE TO KEEP IT

Somewhere dry, with a steady temperature. Not a loft that bakes in summer, where candles bend and adhesive perishes, and not a damp cellar, where cardboard softens and ribbon spots. A cupboard in the flat is better than either, if there is room, and the room there is is the reason the swap box exists.

> **COLETTE'S RULE OF JANUARY**
>
> *Pack it away the way you would want to find it. Next December begins today.*

EVERY FIGURE IN THESE PAGES, COLLECTED

The Christmas numbers

LIGHT

Strands for the tree and the window	2200–2700 K, one batch
Bulbs per 30 cm · 1 ft of tree, glowing	about 100
Bulbs per 30 cm · 1 ft of tree, soft	60–70
Overhead light, all season	off

THE TREE

Height, against the ceiling	ceiling – stand – topper – a hand
Base width, standard · slim	two thirds · half its height
From radiators, stoves, fires	1 m · 3 ft, at least
Fresh cut off the trunk	1–2 cm
Water in the stand	about 1 l per 2.5 cm of trunk

GARLAND AND WREATH

Garland laid along a shelf	shelf + 30–60 cm each end
Garland in swags	about one and a half × the width
Wreath, against the door	half to two thirds of its width

THE TABLE

Width per guest	60 cm · 24 in
Cloth drop · centrepiece height	20–30 cm · under 30 cm
Any flame, from anything that can burn	30 cm · 12 in, or more

All of these are working figures from the trade and from the people who make the things, not laws. Where a maker's label says something different — about how many strands may be joined, about a stand, about a candle — the label wins.

THE AUDIT · DECEMBER

The Christmas audit

ROOM

DATE, AFTER DARK

BEFORE ANYTHING GOES UP

- [ ] Half of what is on every surface is in the swap box
- [ ] The tree has a floor of its own, a metre from any heat, beside a window, near a socket
- [ ] Every walkway still clears a full basket
- [ ] Every strand tested, one batch, warm white, steady setting, on a timer

SITTING WHERE YOU WILL SIT ON CHRISTMAS EVE

- [ ] The ceiling light is off, and the room is still lit at three heights
- [ ] The tree glows from inside; I cannot see a lead
- [ ] I can see the tree twice — in a mirror or in the black window
- [ ] There are no more than three colours, and one metal
- [ ] At least ten things on the tree did not come out of a box of fifty
- [ ] Something living, something wooden, something cloth and something glass or clay are all in view
- [ ] No flame is within thirty centimetres of anything that can burn

SCORE, OUT OF ELEVEN

KELVIN ON THE STRANDS

Fewer than eight ticks: start with the light, pages 6 to 8, and change nothing else until the ceiling light can stay off all evening.

THE ONE ORNAMENT WE WILL ADD THIS YEAR, AND ITS DATE

WHAT I WANT TO REMEMBER WHEN I PUT IT AWAY